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# Rule of law key to prosperous new Syria, Macron says

SYRIANS URGED NOT TO LET BOMB ATTACKS DERAIL COUNTRY'S TRANSITION

**DUBAI**  
BY STEPHEN N. R.  
Senior Associate Editor

French President Emmanuel Macron and Syrian President Ahmed Al Sharaa yesterday agreed to restore full diplomatic ties, deepen economic cooperation and position Syria as a regional trade hub, even as two explosions wounded 18 people near the hotel where the French leader had spent the night.

Macron, the first Western leader to visit Syria since the fall of Bashar Al Assad in 2024, continued his landmark visit despite the blasts, calling on Syrians not to allow violence to derail the country's transition.

"It is necessary that the dictatorship be succeeded by a genuine rule of law," Macron said at a joint press conference with Sharaa, adding that only the rule of law could help build a prosperous new Syria.

## UAE condemns bombing

UAE's Ministry of Foreign Affairs said it condemned the two "terrorist" bombings near the Ministry of Tourism in Damascus, and stressed solidarity with Syria.

UAE also said it "rejects all forms of violence and terrorism that aim to undermine security and stability." The UAE ministry expressed wishes for a speedy recovery for all the injured, the statement read.

## Exchange of envoys

Sharaa announced that Syria and France had agreed to begin exchanging resident ambassa-

■ France's President Emmanuel Macron (left), is greeted by Syrian President Ahmed Al Sharaa in Damascus yesterday.  
AFP



dors "as soon as possible", restoring normal diplomatic relations after France closed its embassy in Damascus in 2012 during Syria's civil war.

Macron urged Syrians "not to let ourselves be destabilised" by the bomb attacks, while Sharaa praised the French president's "courage" for continuing his visit despite the security threat.

Macron said Paris will return more than €50 million (\$57 million) stolen by the family of Al Assad to the country.

The declaration of intent signed by both countries' foreign ministers said that the two nations will "begin the process of returning €51 million from the seizure of Rifaat Al Assad's ill-

gotten gains, confiscated by the French justice system".

## Trade hub

The leaders also unveiled an ambitious economic vision, saying they wanted Syria to become a key regional logistics and trade hub as countries seek alternatives following disruptions linked to the Strait of Hormuz.

"After the Strait of Hormuz crisis, the world realises the value of safe and stable corridors," Sharaa said, adding that Syria had regained its strategic importance as a vital link in global trade routes.

Macron said he hoped to help make Syria "a long-term regional hub" where new logistics, energy and data corridors could be de-

veloped, reducing the risks associated with the Strait of Hormuz.

## Economic partner

Several bilateral agreements were signed during an economic forum on Syria's reconstruction.

## 18 injured in blasts

Earlier yesterday, two improvised explosive devices detonated in central Damascus, injuring 18, including four police officers. One was hidden inside a parked car and another in a rubbish container near the Four Seasons Hotel, where Macron had stayed. The explosions occurred just before Macron arrived at the presidential palace but after he left the hotel.

— with inputs from AFP, WAM

# Dubai air taxi hub gets world's first safety approval

VDX near Dubai airport can handle up to 170,000 passengers a year

**DUBAI**  
BY NIVETHA DAYANAND  
Assistant Business Editor



Dubai has moved a step closer to launching commercial air taxi services after VDX, the flagship vertiport near Dubai International Airport, received regulatory certification for electric vertical take-off and landing aircraft operations.

The General Civil Aviation Authority and Skyports Infrastructure said VDX is the world's first purpose-built commercial vertiport to receive regulatory certification. The approval clears a key infrastructure milestone for Dubai's planned Air Taxi network, which is being developed by Skyports in partnership with the Roads and Transport Authority.

VDX will serve as the first and main hub in the Dubai Air Taxi network, with three more vertiports under development.

## Four-storey facility

The four-storey facility spans about 3,100 square metres and includes two dedicated take-off and landing areas, rapid charging infrastructure for electric aircraft and passenger facilities designed for high-throughput operations. Once commercial operations begin, VDX will be able to handle up to 170,000 passengers a year.

The certification followed a detailed GCAA review of the

vertiport's infrastructure, physical characteristics, operational procedures, safety management arrangements, emergency preparedness and compliance with applicable rules.

"The certification of the world's first purpose-built commercial vertiport is a historic achievement for the UAE and a defining moment for the future of aviation," said Saif Mohammed Al Suwaidi, Director General of the GCAA. "It reflects the vision of our leadership, the maturity of our regulatory system and our national capability to enable innovation while maintaining the highest levels of safety."

The milestone gives Dubai's air taxi plans a stronger regulatory base, which will be critical for public confidence once passenger services move closer to launch. Skyports said construction across the wider Dubai Air Taxi network is progressing, with the certified vertiport now acting as the anchor site for future commercial operations.

"With VDX now certified and construction of the wider Dubai Air Taxi Network progressing at pace, we are one step closer to launching commercial air taxi operations, and unlocking a new era of safe, efficient and sustainable urban transport," said Duncan Walker, CEO, Skyports Infrastructure.



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# Ronaldo's legendary career deserves to be celebrated

The 41-year-old has played his last World Cup match

**DUBAI**  
BY ROBERT ILSLEY  
Sports Reporter

Love him or hate him, but no one can deny the greatness of the phenomenon named Cristiano Ronaldo.

While lifting the World Cup would have been the perfect finishing touch to Ronaldo's glittering career, one missing trophy can never overshadow more than two decades of unparalleled service, success and inspiration for Portugal on the international stage.

The five-time Ballon d'Or winner played his final World Cup match as Portugal were knocked out by Spain in the last 16 of the tournament.

While the 41-year-old cut an emotional figure as he left the pitch for the final time at a World Cup, he can reflect on an international career that brought immense pride to both himself and Portugal.

Before Ronaldo made his senior debut for Portugal in 2003, the national team had never lifted a major interna-



■ Cristiano Ronaldo

tional trophy. Things changed when Ronaldo came on the scene. The nation soon embarked on the most successful period in its footballing history, reaching the Uefa Euro 2004 final on home soil just a year later before suffering a heartbreaking defeat to Greece.

They reached the semi-finals of the 2006 FIFA World Cup before finally ending their wait for a major trophy by winning Uefa Euro 2016, defeating France on enemy soil. Portugal then added the inaugural 2018-19 Uefa Nations League title to their growing list of achievements before winning it again in 2025.

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